



AAKAR INNOVATIONS (COHORT 10)

Aakar Innovations is a startup that has been working as a solution provider in the menstrual hygiene sector for the last decade. Aakar's flagship product is 'Anandi', India's first compostable biodegradable, organic sanitary pad certified by ISO-17088 international compostable standard. It is also the first company to develop a commercially-available bio-SAP based pad which is completely safe and made



entirely of natural materials. Traditional pads often use the widely available commercial SAP (sodium polyacrylate) which can cause skin irritations, rashes and dryness, among other complications, according to Aakar. Tampons containing traditional SAP have even led to fatalities and are currently banned by the FDA in the US for use in tampons. Anandi pads avoid these complications since they are made out of all-natural

elements and compostable bioplastic that does not stay in landfills for over 500 years. The Anandi pads, instead, become manure within 90-180 days in composting conditions or within a year in natural conditions. Aakar has even worked with the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), as a part of their advisory team, to develop compostable standards for sanitary pads in India. BIS even adopted Aakar's compostable testing standard as the national benchmark for biodegradable and compostable pads.

In addition to developing an all-natural, hygienic sanitary pad, Aakar also gives back to society by providing employment opportunities to women, free sanitary pads to school-going girls in need, and menstrual hygiene education and discourse to women and men in villages. Aakar also works towards enabling women to not only use compostable and hygienic pads but also produce pads in women-run mini-factories in villages and distribute these affordable sanitary pads. All while raising awareness about menstrual hygiene management, thus creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for village women. Jaydeep Mandal, Founder, Aakar said, "Aakar Social Ventures works towards educating women and girls as well as men and boys through our behavioural change and communication program which not only covers menstrual hygiene but also sexual education, maternal health, life skills, etc. We talk about the science behind menstrual hygiene, what happens in the 28-35 days menstrual cycle, the connection between menstruation and childbirth, etc. We also involve local school teachers, community leaders, asha, and anganwaris to run awareness programs and our team trains these educators. We promote a bucket of choice, informed choice and freedom of choice among women for choosing menstrual hygiene products".

that have a tremendous social impact but are now also sustainable from a business perspective".

Since its inception in 2017, Nexus has played an important role in the astronomical growth in the entrepreneurship ecosystem in India, more specifically, the Delhi-NCR region. Azulay commented, "It is great to see that entrepreneurship is also becoming aspirational like an engineering or medical degree in India". Nexus takes its role in encouraging the youth of India to embrace entrepreneurship very seriously and to this end, the startup hub conducts open workshops every month that have

experts from the US and India in several fields present to directly connect with aspiring entrepreneurs. The workshops are completely free of charge and are open to anyone who is interested.

Currently located in New Delhi, Nexus, as a US Government program actively works with US Consulates in Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai and Hyderabad in order to conduct different programs across the country. Nexus also attempts to accept as many offers as possible to conduct programs in different cities in India, and has also successfully organised programs outside of India, in neigh-

bouring countries such as Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Bhutan. In addition to continuing its flagship pre-incubation program, Nexus also plans to conduct industry-specific workshops across the country. Azulay adds, "Nexus is also planning to use Hindi speaking trainers to work with entrepreneurs in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities in India. We have seen an increase in requests to speak at colleges and universities and think this is a great way to talk to young students about entrepreneurship and answer some of the questions they have about the opportunities (and pitfalls) of going into business for yourself".